persona ‘significantly focused upon his “manly” leadership style: efficient, dynamic, potent, and capable of removing all policy-roadblocks through sheer force of personality. In this narrative, he was implicitly contrasted with his predecessor Manmohan Singh and more generally against an “effeminate” Indian type who is unable to strike hard at both external enemies (Pakistan and China, say) and internal threats (“Muslim terrorists”, most obviously). His “56-inch chest”—able and willing to bear the harshest burdens in the service of “Mother India”—was a frequently invoked metaphor in the election.’[17]

The BJP banked on Modi’s muscularity to show up what it saw as the weak administrative response of the UPA government to matters of law and order, concerns that are paramount for women. The titles bestowed on Modi, like ‘Bharat Maa ka Sher’ (Mother India’s Lion) and ‘Hindu Hriday Samrat’ (King of Hindu Hearts), blended narratives of masculinity and security with wider Hindutva messaging.[18] So, one actress, Mallika Sherawat, could call him India’s most eligible bachelor in 2014, while another, Sherlyn Chopra, said she would like to be his personal assistant. These could have been publicity stunts, of course. Another actress, Meghna Patel—somewhat like the ‘Obama Girl’ of 2007, whose sexually suggestive serenade to Barack Obama went viral on the internet—shot a series of nude photographs of herself, her intimate parts covered only by lotuses in bloom or images of Modi. These served as online posters, put out with the message ‘Vote for Narendra Modi’. As the Baroda-born actress told a news magazine, ‘Women from the rest of India have only now discovered Modiji’s appeal … In Gujarat, we have known it for over 13 years.’[19]

In Bengaluru, during the 2014 poll campaign, Modi’s appeal among women led to the formation of a female volunteer group, NaMo Bharathi, created solely to ensure that all four constituencies in the city voted BJP.[20] Rasita Anand, one of the founders of this group, told *Open*, ‘All of us have just two similarities—we are all women and we all support Modiji.’ Members of the group set up a temporary office, helped register new voters, went on door-to-door campaigns, and even organised talks and meets with various BJP leaders. Another member of the group, Poonam Vinod Lal, a